

How Do Americans Explain Their Party Identification and Out-partisan Animosity?

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Abstract

Political scientists often claim that partisanship is explained by non-policy factors such as early childhood experiences, parental influence, and group membership. In this paper, we use open-ended survey questions to elicit partisan Americans' own explanations for their affiliations as well as their attitudes toward the opposite party. Policy, values, and ideology are the most common reasons Americans say that they identify as a Democrat or Republican and feel the way they do about members of the other party. The rate at which these reasons are cited far exceeds expectations of published scholars of partisanship. Findings do not vary meaningfully across party, region, gender, race, age, or socioeconomic status.

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How do Americans select their preferred political party, and why do they feel the way they do about members of the other party? Campbell et al. (1960) largely attribute the origins of party identification to “early politicization” (p. 146), although subsequent studies have also discussed the importance of social environment (Klar 2014), group membership (Luttig 2017), group attitudes (Bartels 2018; Robinson and Moskowitz 2019), emotion (Mason 2015), and policy preferences (Bartels 2018; Highton and Kam 2011). Relatedly, accounts of partisan animosity and affective polarization typically argue or assume that attitudes toward parties result from early life experiences, social identities, and group orientations (Iyengar et al. 2019; Mason 2018).

Empirically studying partisan origins is difficult because competing theories are often consistent with the same observable phenomena (Fowler 2020). For example, children might have the same partisanship as their parents because they unthinkingly adopt a social identity or because, having carefully considered their values and interests, they have similar policy preferences. Similarly, partisan animosity is consistent with party identity influencing attitudes toward the other party, disdain for one party causing people to identify with the other, or policy preferences influencing both party identification and attitudes toward the other party (Orr and Huber 2020). Furthermore, leading theories are not mutually exclusive. A multitude of inseparable factors are thought to shape attitudes.

We contribute to the literature on the origins of partisanship by doing something simple and unusual in this literature. Instead of attempting to disentangle the complex web of causal relationships underlying partisanship, we explore explanations from members of the public in their own words. We compare these explanations or justifications to those in the political science literature and to the predictions of political scientists. We do not expect members of the public to offer a comprehensive review of the multifaceted determinants of their political identities and attitudes, nor do we expect all participants to offer an accurate summary. Rather, we believe it is valuable to document how personal

narratives align with or differ from political scientists' understanding of partisanship and how individuals will justify it, and to explore the variation in the types of narratives people offer.

Using open-ended survey questions, we ask Americans why they identify with their party and why they feel the way they do about members of the other party. Policy preferences, values, and ideology are, by far, the most common explanations. Specifically, 56 percent of all respondents and 75 percent of those giving a categorizable answer mention policy, values, or ideology. Only 15 percent of respondents expressed disdain for the other party; 5 percent mentioned a specific candidate; 3 percent mentioned parents, family, peers, childhood experiences, or a long-standing affiliation with a party; 2 percent mentioned the previous performance of the parties; and 1 percent mentioned their affiliation with a group or their attitudes toward other social groups.

To elicit self-assessments regarding origins of partisan animosity and affective polarization, we also asked a different set of survey respondents why they feel the way they do about the other party. Approximately 20 percent of our partisan respondents indicated that they do not hold particularly negative attitudes toward the other party. Among those who do hold negative attitudes, more than two-thirds of them mentioned policy, values, or ideology as an explanation.

We further assessed potential divergence between respondents' personal narratives and academic expectations by drawing on a survey of 65 scholars who have recently published papers on American partisanship in leading political science journals. We asked for estimates regarding how often each pathway was an important determinant of an individual's partisanship or attitudes, as well as estimates of how often each pathway would appear in open-ended self-assessments. Our results differ significantly from scholars' expectations. Collectively, scholars significantly underestimated the share of self-assessments that mention policy, values, and ideology. Additionally, they did not expect the self-assessments to greatly overstate the actual importance of these factors.

We also examine the heterogeneity of responses across different types of respondents. The prevalence of different self-identified explanations does not vary meaningfully by party, gender, race, age, region, education, or income. Interestingly, we find that respondents who report that they are ideologically extreme are more likely to express disdain for the other party, and ideological extremism is a better predictor of references to out-party disdain than is strong partisanship.

By asking people to explain their partisan identities and attitudes, we invite study participants to wade into thorny questions related to the philosophy of causation. An event or phenomenon typically has many causes (Bueno de Mesquita and Fowler 2021, pp. 42-44). For this reason, we did not restrict the length of responses, and we allow multiple categories of explanations to appear in a single response. We also keep the complexity of causation in mind when interpreting responses. Even in cases where a respondent mentions only one factor, this does not mean that other factors did not also play an important role or that ex post justifications reveal underlying causes (Rahn, Krosnick, and Breuning 1994). For example, suppose that group identities influence policy preferences, which, in turn, influence partisanship. A respondent would be right to say that their partisanship is caused by or explained by their policy preferences. But they would also be right to say that their partisanship is caused by or explained by their group identities. By allowing respondents to provide unrestricted responses, we learn which explanations are most salient to them and how they make sense of their own political identity and affect.

One potential concern is that the classification of open-ended survey responses requires subjective judgments. We have classified responses both with human coders and a large language model that was trained on an independent sample of human codings. Classification was highly consistent across different human coders and between human and automated codings. For our main results, we utilize the automated codings, but in the Appendix, we show that our substantive conclusions are largely unchanged if we only rely on human codings.

Another potential concern is that people misrepresent their genuine self-assessments, perhaps composing answers to try to please the researcher or appear sophisticated. Furthermore, people may not know why they support their preferred party but still feel compelled to produce an answer. These are general concerns about survey research, and they may be more pronounced when asking people to provide explanations for their own behaviors. Respondents were assured that their responses would remain anonymous, and there was no indication in the survey that one kind of answer was more desirable than another. Still, we cannot rule out these possibilities and discuss below the distinction between causes and self-assessed justifications.

Our analyses nonetheless contribute to the literature on partisanship and affective polarization for two reasons. First, even if these self-reported explanations cannot be trusted, they advance our understanding of how partisan attitudes are rationalized. They tell us how the public relates to political parties and partisan identity, or lack thereof. Second, our study reveals how public explanations of partisanship differ from scholarly accounts and expectations. Members of the public *claim* that policy and ideology explain partisanship and partisan animosity more frequently than current scholars expect they will.

Literature on the Origins of Partisanship and Partisan Animosity

Partisanship is a powerful predictor of political attitudes and behavior. Attachments to U.S. parties tend to be stable over time, and children often share the attachments of their parents (Green, Palmquist, and Schickler 2002; Jennings, Stoker, and Bowers 2009). But where do party attachments come from? Campbell et al. described partisan identity as a psychological attachment or an affective orientation toward the political parties (1960, p. 121). Affective polarization has been analyzed in a way that largely parallels older debates regarding origins of partisanship (Iyengar et al 2019). And yet,

despite these longstanding and rich literatures, it remains exceedingly difficult to explain the causes of orientations toward parties.

Chosen partisanship has most often been described either as a consequence of early childhood socialization and experience with social groups or, less frequently, a reflection of political goals, interests, and experiences with government. Early evidence of partisan stability, ideological instability, and personal stories of social influence on vote choice suggested that the former set of explanations focusing on socialization were more important (e.g., Sears and Funk 1999; Converse 1964; Campbell et al. 1960). But the strong correlations between partisanship, issue positions, and voting behavior led some to conclude that partisanship is, at least in part, a reflection of substantive interests or underlying value commitments (e.g., Franklin and Jackson 1983; Fiorina 1981; Carsey and Layman 2006; Highton and Kam 2011). The increase in negative feelings toward members of the opposite party may similarly reflect either changes in socialization and evaluation of social groups (Iyengar, Konitzer, and Tedin 2018) or the perception that substantive political conflict increasingly aligns with party divisions (Mason 2015; Webster and Abramowitz 2017).² Here, we will consider evidence for a few specific causal pathways that have been hypothesized to influence partisanship and feelings toward partisans before turning to partisans' own explanations.³

On one side of these debates, partisanship and even affective evaluations of the out-party are seen as a consequence of meaningful political and policy conflict. For example, party leaders and the performance of parties in power can shape attachments and interpersonal relationships. Following

² The perception of increased conflict may be important whether that substantive conflict is increasing (Webster and Abramowitz 2017) or is not (Mason 2015).

³ A comprehensive review of the literature on these two topics would be impossible in this setting. We have attempted to highlight the most influential lines of reasoning.

Fiorina's logic, partisan identity may be influenced by experiences with specific candidates and economic conditions (1981). Interviews before and after a presidential election suggest that political socialization may be driven significantly by experience with candidates and campaigns (Sears and Valentino 1997). The phenomenon of affective polarization is also thought to mirror attitudes toward candidates, in part because common measures of feelings toward parties more closely resemble feelings toward party leaders than feelings toward other members of the public (Druckman and Levendusky 2019).

On another side of these debates, some argue that core values, ideological preferences, and desire for specific governmental action lead people to affiliate with political parties while also influencing their feelings toward other partisans. Following Downs (1957), partisanship has long been treated at least partially as a summary of ideological (issue) preferences (Abramowitz and Saunders 2006, Jessee 2009). Some models of over-time changes in partisanship (e.g., MacKuen, Erikson, and Stimson 1989; Valentino and Sears 2005) and in affective polarization (Bougher 2017) suggest that changes in government performance and substantive political preferences also drive changes in partisanship and affective evaluations. When evaluating how warmly people feel toward Americans with randomly assigned characteristics, survey respondents react more to issue agreement than party identity, even when the policy positions are non-partisan (Dias and Lelkes 2022; Orr, Fowler, and Huber 2023).

At the same time, there is competing evidence supporting the group- or socially-oriented views of partisanship. Ideological extremity is a weaker predictor of political engagement than is identity strength (Huddy, Mason, and Aarøe 2015), and ideologically extreme voters are more willing to adopt their preferred candidate's issue positions than moderates (Barber and Pope 2019). In general, partisan identification and feelings toward out-partisans often appear to reflect a team-based orientation

(Iyengar, Sood, and Lelkes 2012; Mason 2015). Together, this work points toward an account in which partisanship is a social identity more so than a summary of policy or value commitments.

There are several ways in which a partisan team membership may be established without deep ideological commitments or thoughtfully developed policy preferences. First, early-life influence of friends and family may establish life-long commitments to political parties (Jennings and Niemi 1968, Niemi and Jennings 1991), much as one may acquire a favorite sports team. Second, social group attachments can lead individuals to embrace partisan identity and express hostility to out-partisans. In the mid-20th century, religious affiliation, union memberships, and socioeconomic status were common explanations for partisan affiliations (Berelson, Lazarsfeld, and McPhee 1954). Contemporary partisans may use their own group affiliations to determine which party to affiliate with and how to feel about out-partisans (Mason 2015, 2018; Kuo, Malhotra, and Mo 2017). Third, even if their own group membership doesn't influence their partisanship and affective orientation, attitudes toward social groups that are thought to align with parties may still influence attitudes toward parties and partisans, an argument articulated forcefully with regard to race (Tesler 2012; Ahler and Sood 2018; Robison and Moskowitz 2019; Kane, Mason, and Wronski 2021).⁴

In general, political scientists continue to debate the extent to which both party identification and affective polarization should be attributed to substantive political conflict, but there is a limit to the parallels between these two debates. For example, political scientists also hypothesize that disdain for out-partisans contributes to political identity, and that political identity can lead directly to negative feelings toward an out-group. Lees and Cikara (2020) find that partisans overestimate the hostility that

⁴ However, Clifford, Simas, and Suh (2025) find that attitudes towards ethnic and religious groups are strongly influenced by beliefs about the policy preferences of those groups, so even if group attitudes influence partisanship, this may be rooted in policy and substance.

out-partisans have towards them and observe reductions in affective polarization when these misperceptions about the relative hostility of the outgroup are corrected (also see Moore-Berg et al. 2020). On the other hand, Mastroianni, Dana, and Nichols (2024) find that partisans can effectively imitate members of the other party, suggesting that they accurately perceive the views of the other side. Both perceptions and meta-perceptions may be a consequence of party identification in addition to a cause. But this is also true of ideological disagreement, some social group attachments, and perceptions of candidates and party performance.

The debates thus remain unsettled. The processes thought to cause partisanship and feelings toward partisans are rife with potential feedback loops and are generally complicated. Neither cross-sectional nor experimental approaches allow us to differentiate between theoretical models. Panel data has allowed for the study of trends in partisanship and affective polarization (Jennings, Stoker and Bowers 2009; Highton and Kam 2011; Már 2020) but don't exist on a scale that would be necessary to track long-term social developments and are also no panacea for distinguishing among alternative causal accounts. This study will not settle these debates, but given the importance of the questions, we believe the causal narratives put forth by partisans and independents are worth documenting. How do members of the mass public justify or rationalize their partisanship or lack thereof?

Of course, we do not propose interpreting open-ended survey responses as a thorough and accurate assessment of the reasons for a partisan affiliation or affective evaluation. In the context of simple psychological experiments, self-assessments of the causal effect of stimuli often differ greatly from estimated effects (Wilson and Nisbett 1978). Multiple-choice questions about the causal impact of information on attitudes also fail to capture true effects (Graham and Coppock 2021). And even in open-ended questions, many respondents may attempt to rationalize their feelings even if they do not know or will not admit the true causes.

But despite these limitations, direct interrogation of how individuals think about politics is a powerful and regularly used tool for understanding many important political phenomena. For example, Lane (1962) interviewed 15 men with similar backgrounds to explore the contents, sources, and impacts of political ideals that ordinary people hold. Some of our best evidence about how people understand political choices comes from members of the public offering their own explanations for their beliefs and actions (e.g., Cramer 2016, Hochschild 1981, Schildkraut 2007, and Williamson 2017). Many studies have analyzed open-ended like/dislike questions to better understand why voters support one candidate over another (e.g., Miller and Wattenberg 1985; Popkin et al. 1976), although some argue that these responses are rationalizations rather than explanations (Rahn, Krosnick, and Breuning 1994). Open-ended survey questions allow individuals to speak in their own words without the constraint of predefined survey response categories and are increasingly important in understanding public opinion (Grimmer, Roberts, and Stewart 2022, Berg and Ternullo 2025). Scholars rely on open-ended survey questions to understand partisan stereotypes (Rothschild et al. 2019; Busby, Howat, and Myers 2024), group identities and political values (Zollinger 2024), moral belief (Kraft 2018), and identification as political Independents (Allamong et al., forthcoming).

Mass Surveys

In July 2022, we surveyed approximately 2,500 voting-age Americans, recruited through Prolific. Approximately 500 of those respondents identified with or leaned toward one of the major parties and were randomly selected to be asked why they identify with their chosen party. The four authors of this study read and coded all of these open-ended responses. To obtain a larger, more representative sample, in May 2025, we surveyed approximately 5,000 voting-age Americans, recruited

by YouGov. After reweighting, YouGov samples are intended to be nationally representative.⁵ The YouGov respondents were asked the traditional two-part branching questions used to construct the seven-point party identification scale.⁶ We then asked respondents why they identify the way they do. Specifically, respondents were asked “In your own words, [why do you think of yourself as/why are you] [a Democrat/closer to the Democratic Party/closer to neither the Democratic nor Republican Party/closer to the Republican Party/a Republican]?” The specific partisan group mentioned in the question matched the answers they had just given to the party identification questions, and we randomly varied whether they were asked why they *are* or *think of themselves* as a member of that group.

After discovering an error in the question that was administered to pure independents,⁷ YouGov fielded the question above to a new sample of approximately 6,000 respondents in January 2026. In our subsequent analyses, we drop the pure independents from the May 2025 survey who received the erroneous question, we pool respondents from the two sets of YouGov surveys, and we re-weight the pure independents from the January 2026 survey to make the sample nationally representative. We also drop a small number of respondents (less than 5 percent) who did not answer

⁵ YouGov recruits respondents into its national panel from a variety of online sources and provides respondents with incentives, in the form of points, to complete surveys. All respondents provided informed consent and the survey received IRB approval. The sample is weighted to be representative of the U.S. adult population based on a synthetic frame created from the 2019 American Community Survey public use microdata samples, adjusted for 2020 turnout and registration rates at the state and local level.

⁶ Complete question wordings are in the Appendix.

⁷ Due to a coding error, the pure independents were asked why they are or think of themselves “closer to neither the \$wording_democratic_nor_republican Party?”

our open-ended question or who provided a short, meaningless response such as a period, a single letter, or “NA.”

We asked OpenAI’s GPT-4o-mini model to determine whether each response included one or more potential categories of explanations for the respondents’ partisanship. We trained the large language model using our category definitions and the full set of codings from the Prolific survey, and we checked its codings by reading and independently coding a randomly selected sample of responses from the 2025 survey. Our own codings align closely with those of the large language model, and our results are similar if we rely only on either the hand-coded responses or the Prolific data. More details about both surveys and our coding procedure are available in the Appendix.

We selected our categories based on common theories in the literature and our expectations about the extent to which we could reasonably assign responses to each of them. These classifications are not exhaustive or mutually exclusive—for some responses, none of the categories applied, and for others, multiple categories applied. Specifically, we assessed whether each response included at least some discussion of:

- values, ideology, or **policy** positions;⁸
- **disdain** for or contentless opposition to the other party;
- specific **candidates**, leaders, or officials;
- **socialization**, parents, family, peers, childhood experiences, or long-standing affiliation with a party;
- **performance** of the parties and their leaders; and

⁸ We include values, ideology, and policy positions in a single category because the concepts are closely linked and because distinguishing between them would be infeasible in most cases.

- group affiliations (e.g., race, gender, sexuality, religious affiliation, immigrant status, union membership, etc.) or attitudes toward other **groups**.

In our subsequent prose, we use the bolded words from this list as a shortcut to refer to each category.

Of the 10,468 respondents who answered our open-ended question about why they identify the way that they do, 2,021 (19.3 percent without survey weights, 25.4 percent with survey weights) gave an answer that did not fit any of the categories above. We have carefully read and categorized a sample of these responses. We believe some of these responses were miscoded by the large language model. However, most were too ambiguous to classify, many were devoid of meaningful content, a small number reflected that the respondent doesn't know why they identify the way they do or does not care about politics, and a very small number of respondents gave a clear reason that did not map into any of our categories. Uncategorized responses were much more common for independents (57.0 percent uncategorized) than for partisans (14.4 percent uncategorized). Because most of these uncategorized responses do not convey meaningful information, we drop them from some of our subsequent analyses.

Table 1 shows a representative sample of responses that fit into each category. We selected responses for which only one category applied, and we then selected two responses from each category and party. We have lightly edited the responses for grammar and clarity but not substance.

Expert Survey

To characterize the expectations of the research community, we also surveyed published experts in the field. We identified authors of empirical papers on the topic of US partisanship published in the last 10 years in the *American Journal of Political Science*, *American Political Science Review*, *Journal of Politics*, and *Public Opinion Quarterly*. After excluding deceased authors and those for whom we could not find an email address, we contacted 100 published experts, most of whom are political

scientists with academic appointments and who are actively conducting research on political behavior and partisanship.

[Table 1 here]

We emailed these 100 experts in December 2023 and asked them to take a 5-10 minute survey about the factors that drive partisanship and attitudes toward members of the other party.⁹ We indicated that we were planning to publish the average responses but that the responses of each individual would remain anonymous. We collected responses for approximately one month and received responses from 65 (approximately two-thirds) of our expert respondents.

Using the categories described above, we asked respondents to estimate the percent of U.S. adult respondents who would provide open-ended answers falling into each of those categories.¹⁰ For simplicity, we asked the expert respondents to consider only those who explicitly identify with one of the two major parties, ignoring independents who lean toward a party. We clarified that the categories are not mutually exclusive, so their percentages need not add up to 100.

Next, to assess whether experts expect respondents to misreport the causes of their partisanship in an open-ended survey question, we also asked the experts to report the share of respondents for whom each of these categories is actually an important cause of their partisanship. By comparing the predictions of the experts with their assessments of the actual causes of partisanship, we can learn whether and for which categories experts expect greater misreporting in open-ended responses. Experts appear to believe that respondents will overreport the importance of policy, candidates, and performance while underreporting the importance of socialization, groups, and disdain. The level of reporting bias expected by the experts is modest, but it indicates that the experts

⁹ We were unable to locate two experts.

¹⁰ Complete survey instrument appears in the Appendix.

distinguish between stated and actual reasons. As we explain in a subsequent section, we also asked the experts to make similar predictions and assessments about the reasons partisans feel the way they do about members of the other party.

Explanations for Partisan Identification

Table 2 shows our main results from our YouGov surveys on the self-reported explanations for partisan identification. These analyses utilize survey weights to make the sample more nationally representative. In the Appendix, we show the same analyses without survey weights, and the results are similar. The first row shows the share of mass survey responses for which each of our categories applies. The second row excludes the 25 percent of respondents for whom none of our categories applied. Among this sample of respondents who gave an answer that fit at least one of our categories, we find that 75 percent of respondents mention policy, values, or ideology when explaining their partisanship; 20 percent express disdain for or opposition to the other party; 6 percent mention specific candidates; 4 percent mention socialization, parents, peers, or childhood experiences; 3 percent mention the previous performance of the parties; and 2 percent mention group membership or attitudes toward groups. Because the categories are not mutually exclusive, the proportions can add up to more than 1.

[Table 2 here]

The next 7 rows of Table 2 show separate results for each distinct group on the 7-point party identification scale. Independents and weak partisans are less likely to provide categorizable responses, but among the responses that do fit our categories, the types of explanations do not vary drastically across different partisan groups. Policy responses were more common than every other category for every partisan group.

The next row excludes independents and focuses on partisan respondents (including leaners), and the results are similar to those for the full sample. The following row also excluded leaners to focus on those who explicitly identify as a Democrat or Republican in the first party identification question. And the next row focuses only on strong partisans. Across these three subsets of the data, patterns of explanations are highly similar.

The next two rows of Table 2 separately show results for Democrats and Republicans (including leaners). Interestingly, these results do not significantly vary by party. Members of the two parties are approximately equally likely to mention policy, candidates, or groups or to express disdain for the other party. Republicans were somewhat more likely to discuss performance, and Democrats were somewhat more likely to discuss socialization.

The final row of Table 2 focuses on those responses for which exactly one of our categories applied, so these proportions do add up to 1. Among those respondents for whom there appears to be one explanation that is most important or salient for them, approximately three-fourths say that they selected their party on the basis of policy. Table A1 of the Appendix shows the hand-coded results from our Prolific survey. The results are generally similar, but in the Prolific data, we find that policy responses are even more common (84.5 percent of all categorized responses).

Table 3 shows the results of our expert survey and compares them with the results of the mass survey. The first row shows our mass survey results after excluding partisan leaners and uncategorized responses, because the experts were asked to predict the responses of those provide a meaningful response and who identify as Democrats or Republicans, excluding leaners. The second row shows that the political science experts predicted that approximately 60 percent of respondents would mention policy and approximately 35-40 percent of respondents would mention each of the other factors.

[Table 3 here]

Comparing the first two rows, we see that the experts underestimated the prevalence of policy answers, and they significantly overestimated the prevalence of the other kinds of answers. Experts predicted policy explanations to be 1.5 times more common than the next most common reason (groups), but policy is four times more common than the next most common reason (disdain), and 10 times more common than any other category of explanation.

The third row shows the experts' assessments of the actual causes of partisanship, which differ somewhat from their predictions, suggesting that the experts anticipated some level of reporting bias in our mass survey. On average, the experts anticipate that people will overreport the importance of policy and underreport the importance of socialization and groups. However, the differences between the second and third rows are modest, suggesting that the experts expect respondents' answers to align somewhat closely with the actual causes of partisanship.

Table A5 of the Appendix examines the extent to which different factors predict which respondents provide each type of explanation among our mass survey respondents. Most of the estimated coefficients are substantively small and statistically insignificant, suggesting that the explanations for partisanship do not vary meaningfully by partisanship, ideology, gender, race, age, income, education, or region. Controlling for other factors, strong partisans, women, white respondents, and those with a college education are significantly more likely to mention policy. We also find that, controlling for other factors, strong partisans are less likely to express disdain for the other party, while ideologically extreme respondents are more likely to do so.

Effects of Question Wording and Question Order

As previously mentioned, in our May 2025 YouGov survey, we randomly varied whether respondents were asked why they *think of* themselves as a member of their party or why they *are* a member of their party. We also asked all respondents when they first identified with the party that

they do, and we randomly varied whether this came before or after our open-ended question. In Table 4, we test whether these different question wordings or question orderings were consequential for our results. Specifically, for each category, we regress an indicator for whether that category applied to each respondent on indicators for those two randomly assigned features of the survey. The results of these analyses are in Table 4.

[Table 4 here]

When asked why they *think of* themselves as a partisan rather than why they *are* a partisan, respondents are more likely to mention policy and less likely to mention parents and early childhood socialization. If we had just asked a respondent *when* they first identified with their party, they are less likely to mention policy—although this difference is not statistically significant—and more likely to discuss parents and early childhood socialization. Policy is still by far the most common explanation in every condition, but subtle changes to the wording of the question or position of the question in the survey influence how respondents explain their party identification. In separate regressions (not shown), we found no substantively or statistically significant interactions between these two treatments.

Explanations for Partisan Animosity

We use a similar approach to measure explanations for partisan animosity and affective polarization. A subset of partisan respondents from our 2022 Prolific survey were asked to rate on a scale of 0 to 100 how favorable they would feel toward someone who is a member of the opposite party using a standard feeling thermometer. We then asked these respondents, “Why do you feel this way?” and gave them an open-ended text box to provide their explanation. We hand-coded these open-ended responses but modified the categories to better match both the literature on affective

polarization and the answers respondents provided. For each response, we coded whether the respondent referred to one of the following factors:

- values, ideology, or **policy** positions;
- negative reactions to the **character**, integrity, or personality traits of members of the other party;
- group affiliations, attitudes toward other **groups**, or perceptions that members of the other party have negative attitudes toward certain groups;
- specific **candidates**, leaders, and officials;
- personal **experience**, parents, family, or peers;
- previous **performance** of the parties and their leaders;
- **factual** disagreement with members of the other party;
- perceptions that members of the other party hold **disdain** for members of one's own party; and
- rejecting the **premise** of the question or explaining why they do not dislike all members of the other party.

Again, these categories map closely onto explanations provided in the literature for negative feelings toward the out party. We added a category for factual disagreement after discovering responses that object to beliefs held in the opposite party, such as the belief that Donald Trump won the 2020 election, but don't accuse people of lying (character).

Although the literature on affective polarization typically asks why people tend to dislike members of the other party, a non-negligible share of partisans do not strongly dislike members of the other party. In our sample, 17.6 percent of our respondents provided a thermometer rating for members of the other party of 50 or more, and 29.9 percent provided a rating of 40 or more. When

asked why they feel the way they do, 19.1 percent of all respondents rejected the premise of the question or explained why they do not dislike all members of the other party. To better understand why partisans dislike members of the other party, we exclude various subsets of these respondents in subsequent analyses.

Table 5 presents the results of our mass survey on the origins of affective polarization. Note that the format of the table is transposed from that of Table 2. Rows correspond with categories, and the columns correspond with different subsets of respondents. Overall, approximately 55 percent of respondents mention policy, values, or ideology when explaining why they do not like members of the other party, 25 percent mention character or personality traits, 9 percent mention groups, 7 percent mention specific leaders or candidates, 6 percent mention personal experience, 5 percent mention the previous performance of the parties, 3 percent mention factual disagreement, 2 percent mention their perception that members of the other party dislike them, and as previously discussed, 20 percent reject the premise of the question and explain why they do not dislike members of the other party. Six percent provided an answer that did not fit any of our categories. Policy and values are, by far, the leading reasons respondents say they dislike members of the other party. The next most common explanation has to do with the character or traits of members of the other party. In terms of magnitude, policy explanations are 31 percentage points more common (more than twice as common) than the next most frequent response.

[Table 5 here]

In the second column, we exclude respondents who gave a rating of 50 or more to members of the other party. And in the third and fourth columns, we exclude respondents who either did not provide a response we were able to categorize or whose answer was coded as rejecting the premise of the question. Among categorizable responses, 59 percent discuss policy, values, or ideology. By focusing on these subsets of respondents who provide low thermometer ratings or who do not reject

the premise of the question, we can better assess why some partisans dislike members of the other party. Among these respondents, over 60 percent mention policy, and just under 30 percent mention character.

Column 5 of Table 5 excludes leaners and Column 6 focuses only on those who strongly identify with their party. Stronger party identifiers are less likely to reject the premise of the question and slightly more likely to mention character and personality traits. But they are also more likely to mention policy, values, and ideology. For respondents who offered a response fitting into exactly one of our categories, 54 percent mention policy, 22 percent reject the premise of the question, 15 percent mention character, 3 percent mention specific leaders or candidates, 2 percent mention personal experience, and only 1 percent of respondents fit into each of the three remaining categories. Overall, to the extent that partisans dislike members of the other party—and not all do—policy disagreement is the predominant explanation they offer.

Table 6 presents the experts' predictions and assessments of the causes of partisan animosity, drawn from our expert survey. Scholars predicted, on average, that 55 percent of responses would mention specific candidates, 53 percent would mention policy, 44 percent would mention character, 40 percent would mention groups, and 20-35 percent would mention each of the other factors. The experts expect that mass survey respondents will slightly overstate the importance of policy, candidates, character, and factual disagreement, while understating the importance of personal experience and groups.

[Table 6 here]

Comparing these results with the mass survey results—specifically categorizable responses from partisans (excluding leaners)—we find the experts underestimated the prevalence of policy answers by approximately 6 percentage points while they significantly overestimated the prevalence

of almost every other factor. Experts correctly predicted that approximately one in five respondents would reject the premise of the question.

Paralleling the analyses in Table A5, Table A6 in the Appendix investigates variation in stated explanations for partisan animosity across respondents. Most of the estimated coefficients are statistically insignificant. Democrats and older respondents are more likely to mention a specific candidate or leader, and virtually all of these mentions are of Donald Trump. But overall, there is little variation in the stated explanations for partisan animosity by party, ideology, demographics, or region.

Discussion and Conclusion

We present novel evidence about the ways in which individuals explain their own partisanship and feelings of partisan animosity. We do not expect open-ended survey responses to reflect a thorough and consistently accurate description of why each respondent affiliates with a political party or feels the way they do about out-partisans. As discussed above, we assume that some people do not know why they relate to parties as they do and might not be honest about their reasons even if they do. Furthermore, respondents may be differentially identifying more proximate or distal causes. Presumably, different factors we coded affect each other in complex ways, in addition to affecting partisanship. For these reasons, we do not believe that evidence presented here should be used to rule out the importance of factors infrequently mentioned in open-ended responses.

Nonetheless, it is important to acknowledge that large majorities report that their partisan identity and feelings toward the opposite party are directly shaped by their values, ideology and policy preferences. Very few participants mention other leading theoretical explanations, such as their upbringing or the influence of family and friends, even when we prompt people to think about when they initially identified with their chosen party in the prior question. Again, this doesn't mean these factors are unimportant. But these results stand in contrast to findings from past surveys on other

forms of identity in which respondents frequently cite the influence of family on religious identity and service attendance, and state that longstanding support of a sports team is a key reason why they continue to root for the team (Miller 1982, Gallop 2007, Pew 2008). In future work, it may be useful to conduct parallel research on other affiliation-like choices that individuals make to better understand how and whether personal justifications for political affiliations are unusual.

We additionally believe that our expert survey respondents are well aware of the fact that survey respondents are likely to misrepresent or oversimplify the reasons for the partisanship and affect. This is evidenced by the fact that the experts gave somewhat different answers when asked to assess the actual causes of partisanship rather than predict how respondents would answer. Still, policy answers are more common and other answers are less common in our data than the experts expected. We acknowledge that experts on partisanship are not necessarily experts on the nature of open-ended survey data, but it is telling that training in political science was insufficient to yield forecasts that match the observed data. The descriptive trends documented here thus directly contribute to collective knowledge of how the public understands and justifies its partisanship.

Although political scientists often worry that partisanship shapes preferences, most people see their preferences as the reason for their partisanship. However, a minority of partisans do justify their partisanship in terms of disdain for an opposing party and its supporters, as suggested by the literature on negative partisanship (Abramowitz and Webster 2016). This literature has relied heavily on feeling thermometer measures. Although the frequent use of feeling thermometers may be a historical accident, we see value in studying how members of the public justify their responses to this survey measure.

Debates regarding reasons for party identification and partisan animosity share many of the same theoretical foundations. Our results show that stated reasons for feeling thermometer ratings (specifically low ratings of one's opposing party) are similar to stated reasons for partisanship. When

asked why they identify with their party *or* why they feel negatively about members of the other party, the vast majority of partisan Americans mention policy, ideology, and values.

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Table 1. Representative Responses from 2025 YouGov Survey

Category	Democrats	Republicans
Policy	Almost all of the important economic and social policies put into law have been passed by the Democratic Party. Much of the Republican agenda in the past 50 years has been geared toward benefiting the upper 1% and corporations. The social safety net has been a product of Democratic efforts.	I support smaller government but a strong national defense and want the US to support Israel. I also oppose illegal immigration and DEI.
	The Democratic Party's stance on issues is closest to my position.	I mostly lean right but I don't agree with all of the extreme right. Sometimes I agree with the left.
Disdain	The implicit and explicit racism of Republicans.	Because the Democrats became so increasingly vile, treasonous, and corrupt that I could no longer vote for them.
	The Republicans are too nuts.	Democrats are basically evil.
Candidates	Donald Trump	Barack Obama
	I'm a Democrat because the Republican Party has sold out to someone who is a conman and a criminal.	Because of the Schumers and the Feinsteins of the world.
Socialization	I am probably a Democrat because that is what my mother is and that's just how I was raised.	My parents are Republican and showed me how they are typically the lesser evil. I know now you really can't trust anyone.
	I grew up in a Democratic household and have always believed that way.	Because I was raised that way.
Performance	They are the party that has done the most to help the American people.	Because of the sad state New York City was in being run by Democrats.
	Because the Democrats could make the economy better again.	They are making change happen. Low gas prices.
Groups	I'm working class and a former union member.	I think the Republican Party is more in touch with the working class.
	Because I'm living in poverty.	I did not belong to any union; my parents both did. I did not have the same political values as my parents. I've always been a white-collar non-union worker.

Table 2. Explanations for Partisan Identification

	Policy	Disdain	Cand	Soc	Perf	Groups	None	N
All respondents	.556	.150	.047	.029	.021	.014	.254	10,468
Excluding uncategorized	.746	.200	.064	.038	.029	.019		8,447
Strong Dem	.710	.105	.044	.043	.015	.016	.132	2,686
Weak Dem	.512	.078	.033	.050	.014	.019	.338	1,058
Lean Dem	.626	.279	.091	.004	.025	.011	.091	1,182
Ind/not sure	.210	.176	.017	.011	.011	.000	.609	1,203
Lean Rep	.681	.241	.054	.007	.037	.026	.074	1,035
Weak Rep	.560	.066	.072	.022	.029	.015	.285	1,114
Strong Rep	.686	.143	.050	.048	.029	.019	.117	2,190
Partisans	.644	.143	.055	.033	.024	.017	.164	9,265
Excluding leaners	.642	.106	.049	.042	.022	.017	.189	7,048
Strong partisans	.698	.124	.047	.046	.022	.018	.125	4,876
Dems	.639	.143	.054	.034	.017	.015	.173	4,926
Reps	.650	.142	.057	.032	.030	.019	.154	4,339
One Category	.745	.163	.034	.034	.015	.010		7,667

Table 3. Expert Predictions about Explanations for Partisanship

	Policy	Disdain	Candidates	Socialization	Performance	Groups
Mass Survey Results	.791	.131	.061	.052	.027	.021
Expert predictions	.602	.374	.382	.368	.346	.398
Expert assessments	.517	.323	.326	.551	.305	.540

Rows do not add to 1 because responses can belong to multiple categories. Mass survey results exclude independents, leaners, and uncategorized responses. Expert predictions are the average predictions of rates from our expert survey. Expert assessments are the expert assessments of the actual causes of partisanship.

Table 4. Effects of Question Wording and Question Order

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Policy	Disdain	Candidates	Socialization	Performance	Groups
Think vs. are	.124** (.034)	-.052 (.029)	-.016 (.015)	-.048* (.021)	-.023* (.011)	.019 (.014)
<i>When</i> asked first	-.047 (.034)	-.003 (.029)	.011 (.015)	.041* (.021)	.011 (.011)	.004 (.014)
Constant	.639** (.029)	.188** (.023)	.063** (.014)	.055** (.016)	.048** (.012)	.024* (.012)
Observations	4,108	4,108	4,108	4,108	4,108	4,108

*OLS Coefficients with robust standard errors in parentheses; ** p<.01, * p<.05.*

Table 5. Explanations for Partisan Animosity

	All Respondents	Rating <50	Excluding uncategorized	Excluding Reject Premise	Excluding Leaners	Strong Partisans	One Category
Policy	.552	.629	.589	.641	.550	.594	.541
Character	.247	.296	.263	.298	.253	.266	.145
Groups	.086	.101	.092	.099	.076	.102	.009
Candidates	.068	.082	.072	.084	.072	.078	.032
Experience	.056	.056	.059	.065	.060	.047	.023
Performance	.049	.056	.053	.053	.044	.047	.014
Factual	.025	.030	.026	.031	.016	.016	.009
Disdain	.022	.026	.023	.023	.020	.008	.009
Reject Premise	.191	.056	.204		.181	.086	.218
None	.062	.067		.076	.068	.062	
Sample Size	324	267	304	262	249	128	220

Cell entries are proportions of responses coded as belonging to each category (row). Columns do not add to 1 because responses can belong to multiple categories.

Table 6. Expert Predictions about Partisan Animosity

	Mass survey results	Expert predictions	Expert assessments
Policy	.591	.530	.490
Character	.272	.437	.400
Groups	.082	.399	.521
Candidates	.078	.548	.448
Experience	.065	.203	.340
Performance	.047	.353	.322
Factual	.017	.315	.281
Disdain	.022	.290	.300
Reject Premise	.194	.221	.197

Columns do not add to 1 because responses can belong to multiple categories. Column definitions are analogous to the row definitions in Table 3.

Appendix

How Do Americans Explain Their Party Identification and Out-partisan Animosity?

Anthony Fowler, University of Chicago (anthony.fowler@uchicago.edu)
Gregory A. Huber, Yale University (gregory.huber@yale.edu)
Rongbo Jin, Chinese University of Hong Kong (jinrongbo@cuhk.edu.cn)
Lilla V. Orr, University of Richmond (lorr2@richmond.edu)

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Text of Prolific Survey

Generally speaking, do you think of yourself as a...

- Democrat
- Republican
- Independent
- Other
- Not sure

If independent, other, or not sure:

Do you think of yourself as closer to the Democratic or Republican party?

- Democratic
- Republican
- Neither

If Democrat or Republican:

Would you call yourself a strong [Democrat/Republican] or a not very strong [Democrat/Republican]?

- Strong
- Not very strong

If randomized into Why PID and if think of yourself as democrat or republican:

In your own words, why do you think of yourself as a [respondent party]?

If randomized into Why PID and if lean toward party:

In your own words, why do you think of yourself as closer to the [respondent party] Party?

If randomized into Why out-party feeling thermometer and partisans / lean toward a party:

We would like to know your feelings toward someone you might meet.

We'd like you to rate your feelings towards this person using something we call the feeling thermometer. Ratings between 50 degrees and 100 degrees mean that you feel favorable and warm toward the person. Ratings between 0 degrees and 50 degrees mean that you don't feel favorable toward the person and that you don't care too much for that person.

You would rate the person at the 50 degree mark if you don't feel particularly warm or cold toward the person.

The thermometer will start out with the marker at 50. To record your result, click on the marker and move it to the rating you select. *Please note that you have to move the marker even if you want to select a rating of 50.*

Using the feeling thermometer below, how favorable would you say you feel towards someone who is a [opposite party.]



If randomized into Why out-party feeling thermometer and partisans / lean toward a party:
Why do you feel this way?

Text of YouGov Surveys

Generally speaking, do you think of yourself as a...

- Democrat
- Republican
- Independent
- Other
- Not sure

If independent, other, or not sure:

Do you think of yourself as closer to the Democratic or Republican party?

- Democratic
- Republican
- Neither

If Democrat or Republican:

Would you call yourself a strong [Democrat/Republican] or a not very strong [Democrat/Republican]?

- Strong
- Not very strong

May 2025 survey:

Randomly selected half of respondents get this question before the next, and vice versa for the other half.

When did you first think of yourself as [a Democrat / closer to the Democratic Party / closer to neither the Democratic nor Republican Party / closer to the Republican Party / a Republican]?

Randomly selected half get the “are you” wording, the other half gets the “do you think of yourself as” wording. The other text matches each respondents’ answers to the party identification questions.

In your own words, why [are you/do you think of yourself as] [a Democrat / closer to the Democratic Party / closer to neither the Democratic nor Republican Party / closer to the Republican Party / a Republican]?

January 2026 surveys

In your own words, why do you think of yourself as [a Democrat / closer to the Democratic Party / closer to neither the Democratic nor Republican Party / closer to the Republican Party / a Republican]?

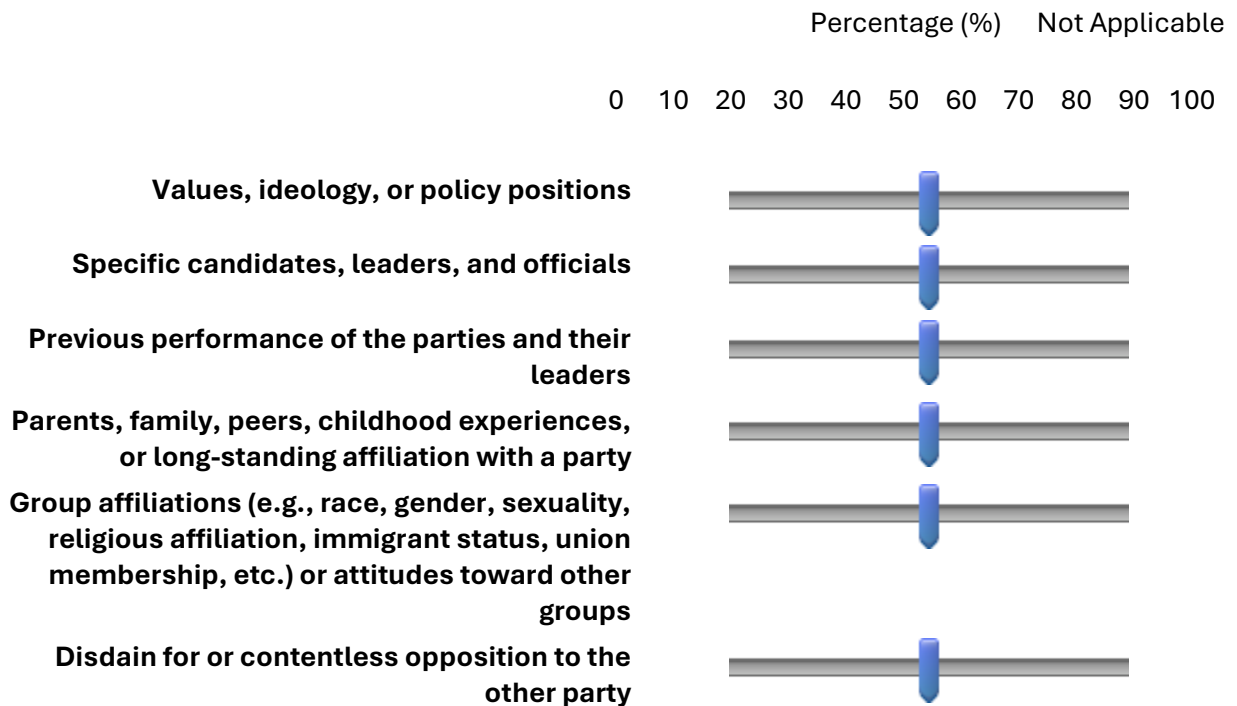
Text of Expert Survey

Suppose we were to ask a representative sample of Democrats and Republicans why they identify with their party. For example, Democrats were asked: “Why, in your own words, are you a Democrat?”

For purposes of this question, assume respondents are those who identify with that party. That is, we exclude independents who lean toward a party.

Among those who provide a meaningful response, what percent of their answers will mention the following factors? Your responses need not sum to 100% because someone might mention multiple factors.

(Note, you must click on a slider to record your answer, even if your answer is 0.)



Are there any additional factors not on this list that you think we should have included? Specifically, are there other common reasons that people would say they identify with their party? If so, please list them below and indicate what percent of respondents you think would mention that factor.

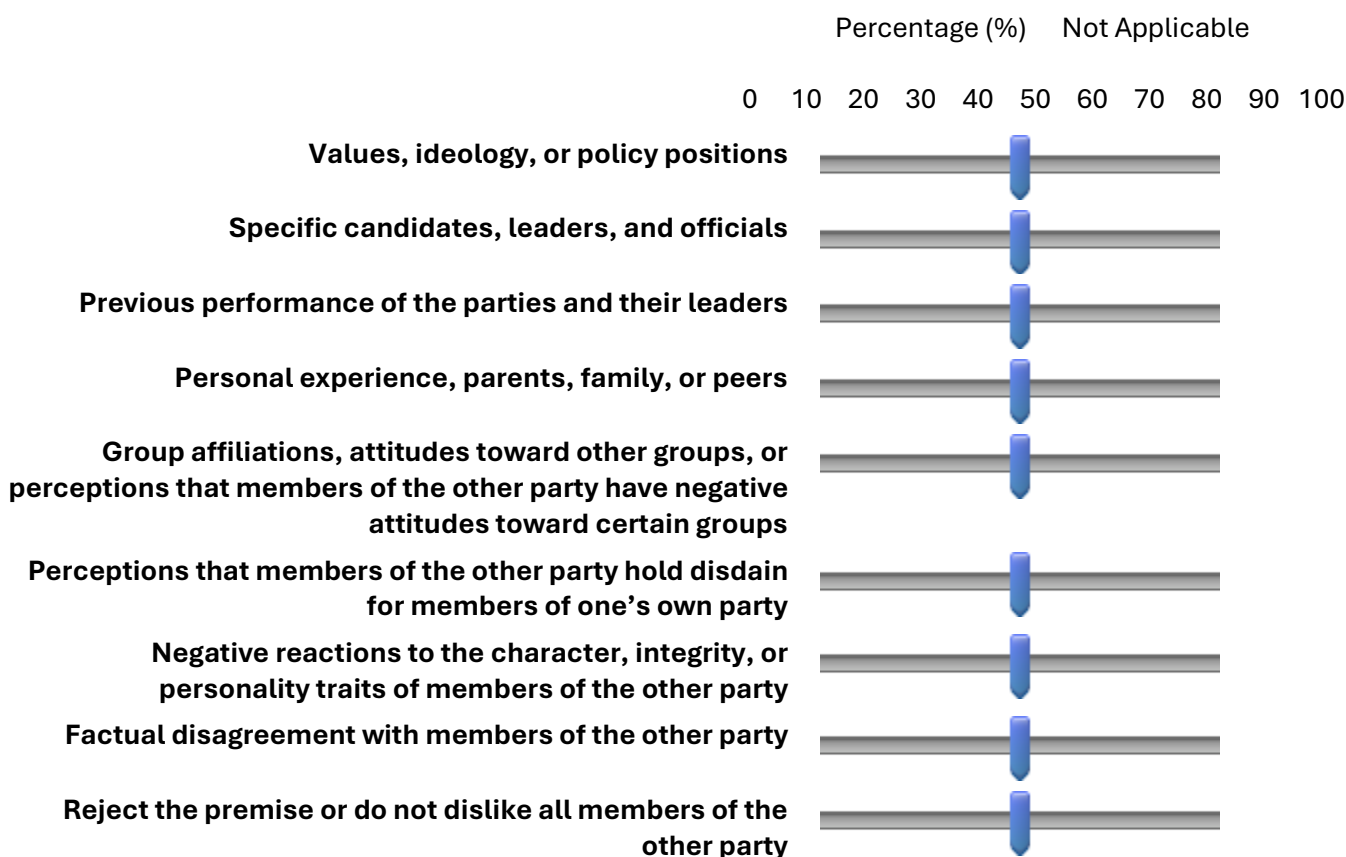
Suppose we were to ask a representative sample of Democrats and Republicans to rate, on a scale of 0 to 100, how warm or cold their feelings are toward someone who identifies with the opposing party

using a feeling thermometer. For example, Democrats were asked: "Using the feeling thermometer below, how favorable would you say you feel towards someone who is a Republican?" Then, we ask the following open-ended question: "Why do you feel this way?"

For purposes of this question, assume respondents are those who identify with that party. That is, we exclude independents who lean toward a party.

Among those who provide a meaningful response, what percent of their answers will mention the following factors to explain any dislike they have for those who identify with the opposite party? Your responses need not sum to 100% because someone might mention multiple factors.

(Note, you must click on a slider to record your answer, even if your answer is 0.)



Are there any additional factors not on this list that you think we should have included? Specifically, are there other common reasons that people would say that explain their feelings toward the other party? If so, please list them below and indicate what percent of respondents you think would mention that factor.

Think about ordinary Democrats and Republicans.

For purposes of this question, assume respondents are those who identify with that party. That is, we exclude independents who lean toward a party.

Regardless of what people say on a survey, for what percent of people are each of these factors actually important causes of their partisanship? Your responses need not sum to 100% because multiple factors might be important causes.

(Note, you must click on a slider to record your answer, even if your answer is 0.)

[Carry forward options in the same randomized order]

Think about ordinary Democrats and Republicans.

For purposes of this question, assume respondents are those who identify with that party. That is, we exclude independents who lean toward a party.

Regardless of what people say on a survey, for what percent of people are each of these factors actually important causes of their negative feelings toward those who identify with the other party? Your responses need not sum to 100% because multiple factors might be important causes.

(Note, you must click on a slider to record your answer, even if your answer is 0.)

[Carry forward options in the same randomized order]

In your professional opinion, what are a few of the most important pieces of scholarship for understanding the contemporary causes of partisan identity/affective polarization in the United States? Self-citations are appreciated too!

In your professional opinion, what are the key challenges in providing persuasive evidence about the causes of partisanship and affective polarization in the United States?

Thank you for sharing your thoughts on the causes of partisanship. We greatly appreciate your participation in this short survey. Please let us know if you have further questions or comments.

Coding of Explanations for Party Identification

For our initial survey of the mass public, we surveyed approximately 2,500 voting-age Americans in July of 2022, and we recruited them through Prolific. Approximately 650 of those respondents were randomly selected to be asked why they identify with their chosen party. The four

authors of this study read all of these open-ended responses and coded which of the categories discussed in the main text applied to each response.¹

Our goal in coding responses was to identify the type of reason/explanation offered by each respondent, regardless of why we might think they really identify with a party. As discussed in the main text, we developed categories related to values/ideology/policy, disdain for the opposite party (or, in the case of independents, disdain for both major parties), candidates, party performance, socialization, and group affiliations/attitudes.

We did our best not to read between the lines of each response, instead taking responses at face value. Because of this, most of our coding decisions were relatively straightforward. We established some general principles and guidelines to help us resolve tricky cases. If a specific factor was mentioned but was clearly not a reason for the respondent's identification, we did not assign the answer to that category. For example, if a Republican states that they agree with the Republican party on policy but they dislike Donald Trump, we did not classify this as a *candidates* answer because Trump is not a reason for their Republican identification.

When an answer was ambiguous, we attempted to err against classifying it as a policy answer. For example, if a Republican stated that they are a Republican because they are a patriot, we did not classify this as *policy*. The term patriot could signal something about their values or ideology, but the term is ambiguous enough that we decided that the policy category does not clearly apply. We made no effort to distinguish between policy, values, and ideology, since these are closely related concepts that would be very difficult to distinguish in a reliable, uncontroversial way.

¹ We initially focused our attention on partisan respondents, and we developed our categories and coding rules without considering independents. In response to feedback, we later went back and recoded the responses of independents, applying the same categories and coding rules as best as possible.

Perhaps the most subjective decisions pertain to the *disdain* category. If a respondent clearly expressed disdain toward or strong negative attitudes about the other party, we applied this category, even if that disdain was not necessarily presented as the primary reason for a respondent's identification. When respondents expressed disappointment with both major parties, for example, "my party is the lesser of two evils," we did not apply the disdain category. But if a respondent simply expressed opposition to the other party without explaining why they oppose the other party, we did apply the disdain category. If a candidate expressed disdain toward a specific candidate but not the party, we applied the candidates category, but not the disdain category.

It can additionally be difficult to classify arguments that relate to group identities and attitudes, our *groups* category. If a respondent says they are a Democrat because the Democratic party supports gay rights, we would apply the *policy* category. The respondent's partisanship is likely shaped by their attitudes toward LGBT Americans and/or their own sexuality, but they *claim* that the party platform is what matters to them. On the other hand, a respondent referencing their own sexuality (or religion, perceived class, race, etc.) or clearly expressing attitudes about a social group while discussing the reasons for their partisanship would be classified as a reference to groups.

Some answers did not fall into any of these categories. Specifically, 4.9 percent of partisans and 36.2 percent of independents gave an answer that did not fit one of our categories. Out of these 68 responses that don't fit our categories, 3 partisans appear to reject the premise of the question by stating that they don't feel strongly about their partisan affiliation, 5 respondents (mostly independents) state they they don't care about politics and/or don't know why they identify the way they do, 5 respondents gave answers that appear to be incomplete or cut off, 9 partisan respondents simply stated that they are registered with a party or typically vote for their party without providing an explanation, and the remaining 46 responses were too ambiguous for us to confidently apply any of our categories. Ultimately, we decided that no additional categories were necessary to describe these

Table A1. Results from Hand-Coding of Prolific Data

	Policy	Disdain	Cand	Soc	Perf	Groups	None	N
All respondents	.756	.167	.040	.017	.028	.015	.105	648
Excluding uncategorized	.845	.186	.045	.019	.031	.017	.000	580
Strong Dem	.868	.147	.016	.016	.011	.000	.042	190
Weak Dem	.757	.117	.072	.027	.009	.054	.090	111
Lean Dem	.843	.147	.078	.000	.020	.000	.049	102
Ind/not sure	.388	.319	.009	.009	.026	.009	.362	116
Lean Rep	.744	.128	.026	.051	.154	.000	.051	39
Weak Rep	.955	.068	.023	.023	.000	.023	.023	44
Strong Rep	.848	.152	.087	.022	.087	.043	.000	46
Partisans	.836	.133	.047	.019	.028	.017	.049	532
Excluding leaners	.844	.130	.041	.020	.018	.023	.049	391
Strong partisans	.864	.148	.030	.017	.025	.008	.034	236
Dems	.831	.139	.047	.015	.012	.015	.057	403
Reps	.853	.116	.047	.031	.078	.023	.023	129
One Category	.848	.116	.014	.016	.004	.002	.000	507

responses. We additionally invited expert survey respondents to suggest important categories we omitted. We received three suggestions, all distinct from each other, which indicated to us that we didn't miss a category widely thought to be distinct from those we proposed.

We coded responses in three stages. First, all four authors coded a randomly selected common set of 100 responses, balanced by partisanship. We discussed these cases and revised our coding rules and categories based on this discussion. Next, we all coded anew all responses, in a random order, including the responses that we had previously coded. Finally, we discussed all ambiguous cases, defined as cases in which exactly 2 of us assigned a response to a particular category. The final codings from each of the four authors were highly consistent with one another. Across all 3,888 respondent-categories, the four coders unanimously agreed in 3,617 cases (93.0 percent), and at least three of the coders agreed in 3,881 cases (99.8 percent). After discussion, we remained split 2-2 in only 7 cases (0.2 percent). For simplicity, in our subsequent analyses, we summarize these decisions by applying a category to a specific response if at least three coders applied that category.

Table A2. Results from Automated and Hand-Codings from Random Sample

	Policy	Disdain	Candidates	Performance	Socialization	Groups
GPT	.62	.18	.09	.02	.01	.08
Author 1	.71	.16	.11	.02	.01	.12
Author 2	.71	.16	.11	.03	.01	.13
Author 3	.72	.15	.11	.03	.00	.07
Author 4	.63	.20	.07	.05	.00	.09

To obtain a larger, more representative sample, we then fielded the May 2025 YouGov survey described in the main text. We trained the GPT-4o-mini model on our hand codings of the partisan respondents in the Prolific data and then asked it to code all of the YouGov responses. We submitted the request through OpenAI’s API platform. We uploaded the coded Prolific data (partisans only). We then instructed the model as follows: “Please categorize the following response into one or more of the following categories: 1. ‘policy’: responses discussing values, ideology, or policy positions, 2. ‘disdain’: responses discussing disdain for or contentless opposition to the other party, 3. ‘candidates’: responses discussing specific candidates, leaders, or officials, 4. ‘performance’: responses discussing previous performance of the parties and their leaders, 5. ‘parents’: responses discussing socialization, parents, family, peers, childhood experiences, or long-standing affiliation with a party, 6. ‘groups’: responses discussing group affiliations (e.g., race, gender, sexuality, religious affiliation, immigrant status, union membership, etc.) or attitudes toward other groups. If the text mentions more than one category, return all relevant categories. If the response does not include any useful information or fails to describe a reason for partisanship, return ‘contentless.’” We gave instructions for the desired formatting of the codings and finally uploaded the data to code.

Table A1 shows the results of our hand-codings of the Prolific data. The format matches that of Table 2 in the main text. The results are generally similar to those in Table 2 (which utilizes data from the YouGov surveys), although policy responses are more common in the Prolific data, and uncategorized responses are more common in the YouGov data.

Table A3. Correlations between Coders

	GPT	Author 1	Author 2	Author 3
Author 1	.803			
Author 2	.793	.978		
Author 3	.768	.828	.808	
Author 4	.799	.816	.829	.725

To check the reliability of the automated codings and to see if the differences mentioned above are attributable to the sample or the coding procedures, we randomly selected 100 responses from the May 2025 survey, and all four authors independently coded them without looking at the automated codings or the codings of the other authors. Each author's codings were generally similar to the automated codings and those of the other authors. Table A2 shows, for the random sample of 100 YouGov responses, how commonly each category was applied by GPT and by each author. The authors were more likely to apply the policy category than GPT, so that explains some but not all of the discrepancy between the Prolific and YouGov results. But in general, the differences between the automated vs. hand coding (or the codings of different authors) are modest.

To further assess the correspondence between codings, we constructed a data set in which each observation is a response-category, and the variables indicate whether each coder applied that category to that response. Table A3 shows the correlation coefficients between all of the authors and GPT. The authors' codings were highly correlated with one another (correlation coefficients ranging from .725 to .978) and also highly correlated with those of GPT (coefficients ranging from .768 to .803). The authors' codings tended to be more highly correlated with those of each other than those of GPT but not significantly so. Therefore, the automated codings appear to be reasonably reliable, and they allow us to analyze data from a much larger sample than we would otherwise be able to code by hand.

Uncategorized Responses

To better understand uncategorized answers, we read and classified a random sample of them from the May 2025 survey. Specifically, we randomly selected 50 uncategorized responses from partisans and 50 from independents. Of these 100 responses, we believe 18 were miscoded, meaning that we believe that at least one of our categories applies. This was the case for 2 (4%) of the uncategorized responses from partisans and 16 (32%) of the uncategorized responses from independents. Among those 18 cases, we would have applied the policy category in 9 cases, the performance category in 11 cases (multiple categories can apply to the same response), the disdain category in 6 cases, and the groups category in one case.

For the 82 cases in which we agree with the large language model that none of our categories apply, we have further classified these responses to understand why some of them do not fit any of our categories. 24 percent of the responses contain no meaningful information. Some respondents wrote gibberish, possibly to get through the survey as quickly as possible. Others gave meaningless answers such as “Skip” or “Won’t say.” 60 percent of the responses provided more information but were still too ambiguous or tautological to provide a meaningful explanation for the respondents’ partisanship. 13 percent of the uncategorized responses indicated that the respondent did not know why they identify the way they do or do not care about politics. And lastly, in 2 of these 82 cases, a partisan stated that they identify the way they do so that they can vote in a partisan primary. These responses, while rare, reflect the possibility that some respondents may not identify strongly with a party but they register with a party for pragmatic reasons, and when asked about their party in surveys, answer in line with their party registration.

Table A4. YouGov Results without Survey Weights

	Policy	Disdain	Cand	Soc	Perf	Groups	None	N
All respondents	.627	.150	.055	.024	.024	.014	.193	10,468
Excluding uncategorized	.777	.186	.069	.030	.030	.018	.000	8,447
Strong Dem	.738	.107	.048	.029	.018	.017	.120	2,686
Weak Dem	.526	.105	.055	.042	.018	.013	.310	1,058
Lean Dem	.662	.265	.110	.005	.024	.012	.069	1,182
Ind/not sure	.236	.195	.010	.005	.007	.001	.570	1,203
Lean Rep	.732	.211	.049	.010	.041	.011	.069	1,035
Weak Rep	.579	.079	.066	.027	.031	.013	.275	1,114
Strong Rep	.711	.145	.057	.035	.035	.023	.103	2,190
Partisans	.678	.144	.061	.026	.027	.016	.144	9,265
Excluding leaners	.673	.114	.055	.032	.025	.018	.168	7,048
Strong partisans	.726	.124	.052	.032	.025	.020	.112	4,876
Dems	.675	.145	.065	.026	.019	.015	.149	4,926
Reps	.682	.144	.057	.027	.035	.018	.139	4,339
One Category	.776	.143	.036	.023	.014	.009	.000	7,667

Results without Survey Weights

Our analyses in Table 2 utilize survey weights provided by YouGov, intended to make the sample more representative of the voting-age American public. Table A4 shows the same analyses but without using survey weights. The results are very similar, so none of our substantive conclusions depend on our use of survey weights.

Variation in Explanations of Party Identification

For each category of responses, we run a regression where the dependent variable is a binary variable indicating whether a response fits into that category (1=yes, 0=no). We include all partisan respondents for whom at least one category applied. The independent variables are all binary variables measuring the partisanship, ideological strength, demographics, or region of our respondents. Specifically, we include indicators for Democrats; strong partisans; those reporting extreme ideology (i.e., identifying as extremely liberal or extremely conservative); women; White people; those who are

Table A5. Variation in Explanations of Party Identification

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)
	Policy	Disdain	Candidates	Socialization	Performance	Groups
Democrat	-.002 (.019)	.028 (.018)	-.000 (.012)	-.003 (.009)	-.014* (.007)	-.010 (.009)
Strong	.057** (.019)	-.069** (.016)	-.018* (.009)	.026* (.013)	-.006 (.006)	-.001 (.007)
Extreme	-.001 (.018)	.039* (.016)	-.030** (.008)	-.007 (.011)	-.007 (.006)	-.007 (.005)
Woman	.072** (.018)	-.085** (.016)	-.025** (.009)	.013 (.011)	-.007 (.006)	.002 (.007)
White	.062* (.026)	.012 (.025)	.006 (.014)	-.029* (.014)	.006 (.008)	-.028* (.012)
Age ≥ 40	-.034 (.024)	.054** (.020)	.002 (.013)	-.013 (.015)	.003 (.008)	-.004 (.011)
Employed	.008 (.020)	-.024 (.017)	-.032** (.010)	.021 (.013)	-.001 (.007)	-.009 (.007)
College	.063** (.020)	-.023 (.017)	.014 (.010)	-.031* (.013)	.006 (.006)	-.006 (.005)
Income ≥ 70k	.037 (.020)	-.019 (.017)	-.021* (.009)	-.012 (.013)	-.005 (.006)	-.015** (.005)
Northeast	-.064 (.035)	.017 (.032)	.042* (.020)	.017 (.023)	.005 (.010)	.017 (.017)
Midwest	-.031 (.021)	.025 (.020)	.006 (.011)	.001 (.009)	-.008 (.007)	.006 (.007)
West	-.000 (.022)	-.007 (.017)	.006 (.010)	.008 (.015)	.001 (.009)	.001 (.007)
Constant	.657** (.038)	.198** (.037)	.097** (.031)	.058** (.014)	.038** (.013)	.058 (.030)
Observations	7,930	7,930	7,930	7,930	7,930	7,930
R-squared	.030	.030	.017	.022	.005	.016

*Robust standard errors in parentheses; ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$. The dependent variable in each column is a binary variable indicating whether a respondent provided a reason for their partisanship coded as matching that category.*

at least 40 years of age; those who are employed full-time; college graduates; those with household annual incomes greater than \$70,000; and residents of the Northeast, Midwest, and West (the South is the omitted region).

Results of these analyses are shown in Table A5. Most of the coefficients are substantively modest, suggesting that to the extent that respondents give different reasons for supporting their

preferred party, these responses do not vary significantly across these groups. There are a few notable exceptions that we discuss in the main text.

Coding Explanations for Partisan Animosity

We modified these categories when coding explanations for feeling thermometer ratings. In this analysis, the *policy* category still identifies responses that root feelings of animosity in negative reactions to those who disagree about important policies or values/ideological attachments. The *character* category identifies explanations that focus on specific flaws of out-partisans, such as being dishonest or close-minded, and was created based on our initial review of responses. The *groups* category is meant to identify responses focused on explanations rooted in the group-orientations of parties, including reasoning based on claims that the opposite party holds negative attitudes toward a social group. The *candidates* category includes the possibility that partisan animosity arises from animosity toward specific candidates and those who support those candidates. The *experience* category includes explanations rooted in personal experience and early childhood socialization.² The *performance* category includes the possibility that partisan animosity results from the performance of elected officials from the opposite party.

We created the *factual* category after reading responses and finding that several referenced factual disagreements with members of the other party (for example, Democratic respondents who mentioned Republicans who don't believe that Joe Biden fairly won the 2020 presidential election). This *disdain* category, which is conceptually distinct from the *disdain* category in the previous section,

² In practice, few respondents explicitly mentioned parents, family, or early childhood experiences in response to this question. One exception is a Democrat who gave a favorability rating of 60 to Republicans and wrote, "My whole family is Republican." In other words, the respondent who explicitly mentioned their family or early childhood experiences appears to have been explaining why they do not dislike members of the other party. Almost all of the responses in this category make reference to personal experience. For example, one Democrat wrote, "I've rarely met a Republican who I enjoy being around . . ."

captures responses that explain animosity as a reaction to the animosity or negative feelings of the outparty toward them (second order beliefs or reflected animosity). Finally, the *premise* category denotes responses where the respondent rejects the premise of the question by indicating they did not feel negatively toward all members of the out party, most often by saying they distinguish among out-partisans or giving reasons why they like out-partisans.

Because the literature on affective polarization largely focuses on negative attitudes toward members of the other party, we applied these categories (other than the *premise* category) based on whether the category is the reason the respondent dislikes members of the other party. For example, if a respondent indicated that they disagree with the other party on policy, but they think there are some good and honest people in the other party, we would apply the *policy* category but not the *character* category. We would also apply the *premise* category because the person provided a reason that they do not dislike all members of the other party.

We reserved the factual disagreement category for cases of genuine disagreements about facts. For example, one Democratic leaner wrote, “70+ percent of Republicans believe an outright lie and pushing that lie is a threat to our Democratic system.” The respondent perceives that most members of the other party hold a belief that the respondent believes to be false. Therefore, there is a factual disagreement, and this category applies. Alternatively, if a respondent accused members of the other party of lying or dishonestly, this does not necessarily reflect factual disagreement. Lying implies an intentional misrepresentation of the truth, so we would code this as impugning the *character* of the other party.

We did not apply any category to 20 responses. In 6 out of 20 cases (30 percent), the answer was blank or cut off. In 3 out of 20 cases (15 percent), the respondent simply restated that they do not like members of the other party but made no effort to provide a reason. And in the remaining 11 cases (55 percent), the answer was too ambiguous for us to confidently apply any of our categories.

For example, one Republican leaner wrote, “They are dissimilar to me,” without specifying a particular dimension of dissimilarity. For our analyses, we exclude these 20 non-answers.

The codings from each of the four authors were slightly less consistent than those about explanations for partisanship. Across all 2,916 respondent-category pairs, the four coders unanimously agreed in 2,661 cases (91.3 percent), and at least three of the coders agreed in 2,902 cases (99.5 percent). We were split 2-2 in only 14 cases (0.5 percent). As before, we summarize these decisions by coding a category as applying to a specific response if at least three coders applied that category.

Variation in Explanations of Partisan Animosity

Paralleling the analyses in Table A5, Table A6 investigates variation in stated explanations for partisan animosity across respondents. As in Table A5, most of the estimated coefficients are statistically insignificant. Policy appears to be the most common explanation for partisan animosity for all demographic groups. Perhaps as expected, those who identify as ideologically extreme are more likely to mention policy, although this estimate is not statistically significant. Residents of the Northeast are more likely to mention policy than those from other regions. But interestingly, we find substantively modest and statistically insignificant differences by party, gender, race, age, education, and income.

Including the Northeast estimate mentioned above, there are only 6 statistically significant estimates of interest in Table A6. White respondents are less likely to impugn the character of members of the other party. Ideologically extreme respondents are more likely to mention groups. Democrats and older respondents are more likely to mention a specific candidate or leader, and virtually all of these mentions are of Donald Trump. And lastly, as expected, strong partisans and those who are ideologically extreme are less likely to reject the premise or state that they do not harbor animosity toward members of the other party.

Table A6. Variation in Explanations of Partisan Animosity

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)	(6)	(7)	(8)	(9)
	Policy	Character	Groups	Candidates	Experience	Performance	Factual	Disdain	Premise
Democrat	-.024 (.067)	.070 (.058)	.055 (.029)	.103** (.029)	.038 (.024)	-.072 (.040)	.030 (.021)	-.027 (.022)	-.117 (.063)
Strong	.054 (.062)	.036 (.058)	-.016 (.037)	.016 (.029)	-.028 (.029)	.005 (.030)	-.014 (.014)	-.039 (.022)	-.148** (.045)
Extreme	.131 (.067)	-.000 (.066)	.113* (.049)	.024 (.034)	.030 (.035)	.003 (.035)	.022 (.022)	.038 (.030)	-.131** (.040)
Woman	.020 (.056)	-.040 (.052)	.021 (.033)	.028 (.029)	.031 (.029)	-.026 (.028)	-.028 (.019)	.004 (.016)	-.031 (.044)
White	.114 (.073)	-.147* (.068)	-.096 (.052)	.015 (.032)	-.011 (.037)	-.009 (.037)	.014 (.021)	-.031 (.025)	.033 (.052)
Age ≥ 40	-.075 (.061)	.024 (.055)	-.007 (.034)	.119** (.037)	.004 (.031)	-.017 (.027)	.035 (.023)	-.008 (.016)	-.001 (.050)
Employed	-.099 (.060)	-.057 (.055)	-.017 (.037)	.004 (.030)	-.026 (.032)	-.036 (.034)	-.006 (.018)	.024 (.016)	.053 (.049)
College	-.049 (.066)	.016 (.061)	.034 (.038)	-.042 (.033)	.013 (.030)	-.006 (.035)	-.034 (.025)	.006 (.020)	.005 (.053)
Income ≥ 70k	.050 (.063)	-.035 (.057)	-.033 (.037)	.030 (.034)	.027 (.028)	.034 (.030)	.010 (.023)	-.018 (.023)	-.037 (.050)
Northeast	.175* (.078)	.028 (.071)	-.045 (.043)	.087 (.050)	-.028 (.033)	.010 (.039)	.003 (.025)	-.031 (.018)	-.097 (.065)
Midwest	.117 (.079)	.055 (.072)	-.059 (.039)	.008 (.033)	-.008 (.036)	.003 (.034)	.030 (.030)	.001 (.028)	-.085 (.063)
West	.086 (.075)	.048 (.067)	-.001 (.048)	.039 (.039)	.017 (.038)	.016 (.036)	.007 (.023)	-.016 (.020)	-.063 (.059)
Constant	.474** (.103)	.332** (.093)	.121 (.062)	-.105* (.046)	.025 (.047)	.134* (.054)	.004 (.029)	.074* (.037)	.404** (.089)
Observations	304	304	304	304	304	304	304	304	304
R-squared	.067	.040	.080	.095	.025	.034	.043	.042	.113

*Robust standard errors in parentheses; ** $p < 0.01$, * $p < 0.05$.*